

Species: Purple Finch Carpodacus purpureus  
(Vernacular Name) (Scientific Name-use binomial)

Date(s): 30 October 1976 Time Bird Seen: late morning for 30 minutes

Locality: Barr Lake State Park

Nearest Town: Brighton County: Adams

Other observers who independently identified this bird:

| NAME | ADDRESS | TELEPHONE |
|------|---------|-----------|
| None |         |           |

Optical Equipment: 7 X 50 binoculars

If photographed, type of equipment used: \_\_\_\_\_

Light Conditions: overcast

Distance from bird (how measured): 20-30 feet

Number of Birds Seen: 2 Sex: ? Plumage: one immature male, other female or immature

Describe the bird's overall behavior and demeanor:

Observed feeding among weeds bordering canal on east side of lake. In the same area as a flock of Tree Sparrows, but not associating with any other birds. Quite tame and unafraid.

Describe in great detail the bird's size, overall shape, plumage and color-pattern. Include details on shape of bill, wings and tail. Give particular emphasis to the marks you used to identify the bird. Reference to its resemblance in field guide descriptions is not enough. Describe what you actually saw in the field:

Moderately large finches (larger than a House Finch), large-headed, chunky-bodied and short-tailed. Bills thick, heavy, blackish, and it was carefully noted, repeatedly at close range, that the culmen was curved throughout. Crown dark brown with a few short, black streaks. A strong, well-defined dark brown auricular patch. A strongly defined, bright white postocular stripe, less well-defined anterior to the eyes. Throat white, with a strong, wide blackish-brown malar stripe. Underparts white, strongly marked with broad, brownish streaks (much broader than streaks of a House Finch), streaking ending abruptly at legs. Undertail coverts white, and totally unmarked. Back brown with wide dark brown streaks. Wings brown with two series of pale spots forming two incomplete and indistinct wingbars. Rump on one individual fairly bright yellowish-olive, with short brown streaks (this color probably indicates the bird was an immature male). Rump not seen on the other individual. Tail short, fairly deeply forked, brown in color. Eyes black. Leg color not noted.

Describe the bird's song or call, if heard, including method of delivery, i.e., from perch, in flight, etc:

None heard.

Describe the habitat in which you observed this bird:

Weedy, rank growth along edge of canal, with open grain fields on other side of canal, and cottonwood-willow growth on same side of canal as birds.

How were similarly appearing species eliminated?

House Finch-Larger size, thick, heavy bills, strong face pattern, heavy, wide streeaking on underparts, clear, unmarked undertail coverts very easily eliminates the House Finch. Cassin's Finch-The only species that could realistically be confused with the Purple Finch. It was eliminated on the following points: (se Identification of Purple and Cassin's Finches, by J. V. Remsen, Jr. in C.F.O. Journal, Fall 1975, No. 25 and Birding, Vol. 8, No. 4, July-August 1976).

Bill-Purple has a curved culmen throughout, Cassins' has a culmen only partially curved, giving the two species a different-looking bill.

Undertail coverts-Always streakked in Cassin's, not in Purple.

Breast streaking-Much broader and less sharp and distinct in Purple than in Cassin's.

Face pattern-Purple has a strongly defined face pattern with a strong auricular patch and postocular stripe. These are paler and far less distinct in the Cassin's.

Back streaking-Sharper and more constrasting in Cassin's than in Purple

Prior experience with this and similarly appearing species:

I am very familiar with House Finches. I have seen the Cassin's Finch on a number of occasions. I have seen the Purple Finch on a number of occasions in Michigan and California, and once in Colorado(at Barr 24 October 1975-record accepted by CFO committee).

Books, illustrations and advice consulted and how did these influence this documentation?

Above article used, confirmed identification.

This report was written from notes made during X after \_\_\_ observation; from memory \_\_\_

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